Assam Rifles that had to divert a portion of its trained forces to Gorkha battalions.

The Chinese attack on Eastern Tibet even while the Simla Convention was in effect may have had a major role to play in the Tibetans agreeing to give up certain areas that were under their control. In the exchange of notes attached to the convention, Tawang was made a part of India. Though not formerly acknowledged, the British negotiators did not want to make any direct payment for Tawang, for it would ‘make us a party to interference with the integrity of Tibet’. In the agreement with Lonchen Shatra, it was agreed that money would be paid later, ‘for some supposedly unconnected purpose’. In the event, a month after the convention was signed and Tawang ceded to British India, the Tibetans were given 5,000 Lee Enfield rifles and 500,000 rounds of ammunition.

The annexation of the Chumbi region into British India did not happen only because at the time it did not have a border with India, flanked as it was to the southwest by Sikkim, and the southeast by Bhutan. The handing over of Tawang to the British did not go down particularly well with the Loseling College of Drepung Monastery which had lost a major source of income. To further complicate matters, London was adamant about the strict adherence to the 1907 Anglo-Russian Treaty. By the time this policy was changed, with fighting breaking out between the Tibetans and the Chinese in 1917, British officers in India had already taken the decision to keep the 1914 Simla Convention under wraps.

The Simla Convention was badly handled by the British. The veil of secrecy that was adopted by them allowed the Chinese to question its very validity. Subsequently, the Chinese even accused the British of having lied about the McMahon Line.

THE BOUNDARY CRYSTALIZES

In the immediate aftermath of World War I, the Assam Rifles continued to build a formidable reputation for itself. The Kuki uprising (1917-1919) was effectively dealt with, as was the crisis in the Chin and Lushai Hills at the same time. Many men had fought with regular army units during the Great War and as they now returned to their parent units, all Assam Rifles battalions found themselves oversubscribed in NCOs and men.

The 1913 survey and the subsequent 1914 drawing up of the boundary had placed Tawang well south of the McMahon Line. Though this was kept